

SPOILERS FOR WARRIOR CATS THE BROKEN CODE!!!

Rootspring could still remember the fateful moment that he had lost everything.

It was countless moons ago, during the fight with ashfur, he was one of the lights in the mist that led the fight against ashfur after he severed their link with starclan and the dark forest, threatening to destroy them both because his perceived soulmate had rejected them. Ashfur had dragged the limp medicine cat shadowsight to the black ink-like water that had surrounded them in the dark forest, trying to throw him in so that he would be lost forever. Instead, bristlefrost had barged into ashfur and sent them both into the water, saving the clans, all the spirits ashfur had controlled, and shadowsight but at the cost of her own life. He had ran over to the water as she fell in, but it was already too late. There was no way to carry her out, he couldn't even see her thorough the opaque pitch black water. As as link with starclan had returned after ashfur was gone the water that had swallowed her had receded, like it was a door to another world just like the moonpool, there was a puddle, then nothing. No hole or gap to explain how the forest floor had seem to swallow her whole.

After it rootspring had tried all he could to find bristlefrost, but she seemed she was gone. He had the ability to sense things through the earth just like his ability to see ghosts, but he could neither summon the ghost or sense her through the ground, even if she was still alive there where no chance she was awake or could sense her after the water had faded and broke the link between him and her. He had felt the danger of it himself when he had fell into the water once, it seemed to sap his strength and his will, leaving cats with a horrible sense of despair. He had tried to forget it, like it was all a bad dream. But it had still stung, even now. He wondered if he would ever feel okay again, he had already grieved long ago so why did he feel so hollow? There was deep need in his heart to be close to someone again, but it had never happened. She was one of a kind, and so was he, nothing else would work.

Maybe he should try again? It wasn't like the living world, there was nothing truly living in the dark forest, but that means nothing was really dead either. No fish roamed the lake, there was no grass, there were old trees that without sun could never live but there were no bugs to eat the bark or anything to rot the trunks. There's a chance that she was perfectly preserved neither alive or dead, resting in the dark water, he just needed to find her.

His thoughts whirled. Past, present, and future, all at once. He had seem just as dull as the cats that ashfur had controlled, his thoughts dull and his passion for being a warrior sapped. He knew he had to look for her, it didn't matter what happened to him and he had the power to see it thorough. He tried to remind himself why he couldn't have done it back then, when she had initially fallen into the lake. He was unprepared, his powers were weaker with less practice, he was younger! He tried every single thought to repress his grief and guilt as he got ready to save her now but he was inconsolable.

Something in his heart still manage to hold onto what he had learned. It was slow at first, remembering his training with the sisters. The powers he had were part of their unique bloodline and they had taught them to bring them to the surface, to put his heart to the floor each day and try to listen to the earth, they said it would show him the way. Moons seem to pass by in an instant, each day he would come to dark forest and search the countless puddles in the new expanded area, the forest seemed to stretch on forever and wound in circles like a maze.

One day, he found himself face to face with shadowsight. Shadowsight also still felt a tug to this dark place and they managed to eventually meet. Rootspring had told his friend about his plan, rootspring was so guilty about it and worried shadowsight would tell him to let bristlefrost go, but he was actually supportive and gave helpful information. When he had returned to the dark forest with bristlefrost they had undergone a small ceremony with the sisters to protect their inner hearts. While he couldn't

remember how it was done to do it now or give it to rootspring, he had a hunch that it could still be active for bristlefrost, rootspring just had to search for her heart. It had gave him new confidence knowing that she could still be found, she wasn't completely swallowed by the dark water, her heart was still resonating and preserved. Moons passed even faster with his friend beside him. Coming up with plans by drawing it in the soil with their claws, marking territories they had searched, and trying to retain their strength together. But try as they might, rootspring still felt himself changing from the place, it was said to "turn a good cat bad" by corrupting their thoughts since you had to think dark thoughts while sleeping to even get there, but maybe this was a blessing in disguise?

Ashfur had control over spirits, the dark forest, and the terrain by just becoming close to it, it could increase the range of rootsprings earth sensing and he could make a vine to dive into the pool with like how the vines lengthened and strengthened the more hate and fear was felt, he just had to hold onto that feeling and nurse a vine for use later while he held his breath. Both in fear for what was to come, and to practice holding his breath for diving into the water, failure was not an option. Time kept passing, he could feel his senses stretching ever farther. As he put his paws into the dark water once again he could feel his senses stretching out like roots of a tree, searching for her heart in eternity. That day, he had found it.

He and his friend shadowsight went over the plan again as shadowsight had help rootspring tighten the end of the vine against him, preparing to dive. Rootspring laid down, feeling his heart to the earth, not only trying to locate her but trying to pull her toward her. Creating small pools of water around him, trying to find a connection to her that was close. When he had found it rootspring stood up and tried to brace himself.

"Be careful okay?" Shadowsight mewed. 'I always do' Rootspring mewed back 'Ill give the vine a tug when I have found her alright?' "Alright..." "Good luck." Rootspring just nodded back briskly, He didn't want to waste anymore time, this was happening tonight.

He dived in and instantly felt the familiar feeling of despair from the liquid and it surrounded him and entered his ears and travelling to his thoughts, even with all the time of him putting his paws in the liquid and trying to be one with it the feelings were still extremely strong, but he was stronger, he knew he was. He held his breath well, getting a lot of practice over the moons. He was surprised he could see at all in the dark water, maybe because there was no stars there that means a constant low light covered the whole area from- somewhere... It didn't really matter right now. As he kept diving further and further, his tail and the vine around him trailing towards the surface, the feelings of despair got stronger and stronger the further down he swam, he began to think if this was a mistake, but didn't stop moving while thinking.

He knew he couldn't let go. Bramblestar was saved because squirreflight didn't let go, thunderclan and all the clans were saved because noone let go of what they truly wanted. The sisters and tree both told him what he wanted to hear about bristlefrost, they thought cross-clan relationships were right and they all worked with starclan to make it possible for the first time, if only it was possible a long time ago so that they could've spent time together before they were separated forever. The rule was made to prevent future pain, but rootspring couldn't help but feel a deep pain of resentment every time he saw someone else happy, it pained his entire core like he was about to break, his need to be with her was so strong, he loved too much.

"He loved too much"? Where had he heard that before..? With a sudden start, he remembered. Ashfur. They had said ashfur loved squirreflight too much, he had done everything he did just to be together

with her once again. So much subterfuge and destruction, just for love? No, it was obsession. But- he was obsessed too! He couldn't stop thinking about bristlefrost, was he like ashfur? 'No, no, no!' He thought, it couldn't be true! But- he had done all the same things... He took control over the dark forest, just like him, he betrayed everyone in his clan by coming back here, his resentment and visits to the dark forest had made him uncaring and cruel to people around him. He really was...

ASHFUR-!

As if he had summoned him, bright blue eyes appeared in front of him with the trailing form of his grey pelt trailing below him, frozen in a face and pose of desperation and fear. Preserved. It was horrifying, and as he came to his senses he started to notice the same thing all around him. Like reeds under the water, cats seemed to lay vertically with their mouths to the sky, countless spirit cats all around him, never moving, never fading, forever frozen. The sight chilled him to the bone and made it even harder to fight the feelings of despair, was bristlefrost still here? He desperately scanned the ocean floor, it wasn't visible. The bodies piled on top of each other, completely covering the floor, so many cats... Eyes rolled back, mouths lolled, mouths twisted in pain, but with no bubbles escaping ever again. You name it, that pose was there, countless lives lost.

Still searching, trying to feel the earth- while floating in the water, he sent his senses out, searching for her heart. He swam towards it, feeling terrified the eyes of the frozen cats would look at him and when he swam in front of their gazes, but they never moved. He wasn't sure what scared him more, them being conscious and suffering but still alive or unconscious and trapped forever in a long sleep. Then, he saw her. Floating there in front of him. She seemed, oddly happy? Her face wasn't in pain, her eyes were closed unlike all the others, her pose was relaxed, she accepted it..? But why? Wasn't she desperate to get out? Or maybe the time they spend together was enough for her? Both thoughts broke his heart, but he was still overjoyed to see her.

He didn't realise that the vine had loosened and started to drift away from him! His joy had caused it to slack and float away! Quickly, he swam up to grab it. Flailing his paws desperately and then reaching up and clasping the vine with his front paws. 'That was way too close.' He thought. Quickly he tied the vine back around him and thought dark thoughts to tighten it once more. Then he kept pulling the top of the vine with his front paws till it jerked to alert shadowsight to pull him up and then quickly dived to bristlefrost and wrapped all four of his paws around her.

He was slowly dragged up with bristlefrost, slowly watching all the frozen cats below him trail out of view, things would never be the same, he could finally be with her. Maybe- it wasn't bad to love so much, as long as you protect the ones you love.